

Game 4

□ Mariano ■ Cvitan

Mendrisio 1999

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Be2 e5 7 d5 a5 8 Bg5 h6 9 Bh4 Na6 10 Nd2 Qe8 11 0-0

Sometimes White delays castling but this shouldn't deter Black. He should just adopt exactly the same plan as in the game.

11...Nh7!

This is the only way to develop play on the kingside.

12 a3

White now threatens to play b2-b4 because after an exchange of pawns on this square the black knight on a6 will be pinned.

12...Bd7 13 b3

Most White players take the threat of ...a5-a4 seriously and resign themselves to this loss of tempo. There are a few who ignore it but the position after 13 Rb1 a4 is considered very comfortable for Black. The point is that 14 b4 can now be met by 14...axb3 15 Nxb3 b6 when it will be difficult for White to generate any sort of queenside play at all.

13...h5



WARNING: When Black plays ...h6-h5 in this variation White must immediately check to see if his bishop on h4 is safe. It certainly isn't here as Black now threatens 14...g5 and 15...h4.

14 f3

White safeguards his bishop.

14...Bh6 (Diagram 13)

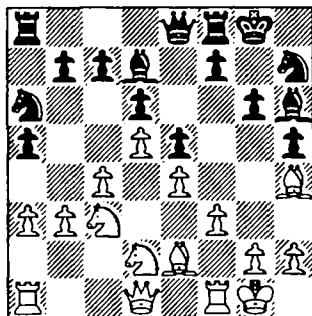


Diagram 13

A new diagonal for the bishop

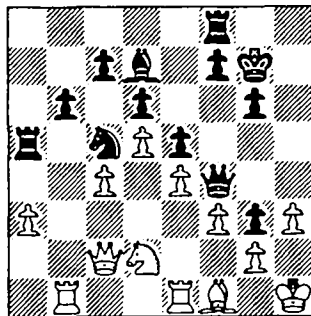


Diagram 14

White is positionally lost

The bishop is heading for e3. White must now decide if he is going to allow this move and live with the active bishop, to allow ...Be3 but ex-

change bishops, or to prevent it altogether. In general, White would prefer to avoid an exchange of bishops because this will weaken his control of the dark squares.

In this book you will often see phrases like 'White has complete control of the light squares' or 'Black dominates the dark squares'. I remember from my early days as a chess player that this can be a difficult concept to grasp. Basically, control of a colour complex usually happens when the opponent's bishop of that colour is missing and the central pawns are on the opposite colour to the missing bishop. For example, if White has pawns on f3, e4, d5 and no dark-squared bishop he can be said to be weak on the dark squares. If Black can then get his own bishop on this diagonal (g1-a7) then it can be said that he controls the dark squares. It can be so important that players are often willing to give up an exchange to achieve this control.

15 Bf2?!

The majority of players prefer to tolerate the active bishop. The main line runs 15 Rb1 Be3+ 16 Kh1 Bc5! 17 Qc1 with a complex game. The problem with dropping the bishop back to f2 is that it allows Black a free hand on the kingside. On h4 it kept the black queen under wraps.

15...Qe7! 16 Qc2 h4 17 Rab1 Bf4! 18 Rfd1 Qg5 19 Kh1 Nf6

The way Black has developed his kingside play is very typical for this variation. A key idea now is ...Nh5-g3+ while the attack can also be supported by ...Kg7 and ...Rh8.

20 Bf1! Nh5 21 Ne2 Ng3+! 22 Bxg3 hxg3 23 Nxf4 Qxf4 24 h3 Kg7 25 b4

Finally White gets to play an active move on the queenside.

25...b6 26 bxa5?

However, his second active move is a mistake which costs him the game. White's position on the kingside is quite perilous in the long term but he has at least weathered the initial storm. Probably the last thing he was expecting was to fall to pieces on the queenside.

26...Nc5!

Threatening 27...Ba4. Sacrificing the exchange would be hopeless because of the powerful black pawn on g3. It's better to have two rooks than one when there are tactical possibilities on the back rank.

27 Re1 Rxa5 (Diagram 14)

White's position is a disaster. He has weaknesses on the queenside and a bishop condemned to life behind his own pawns.

28 Qc3 Rh8 29 Qe3 g5 30 Qxf4 gxf4 31 Ra1 Rha8 32 Nb1 f5
White resigns

White Plays 7 Be3

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Be2 e5 7 Be3
(Diagram 15)

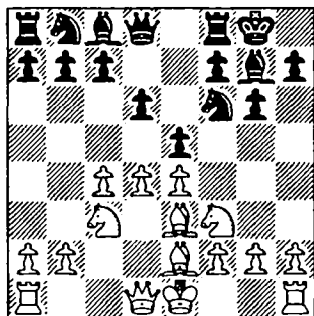


Diagram 15
The Gligoric System

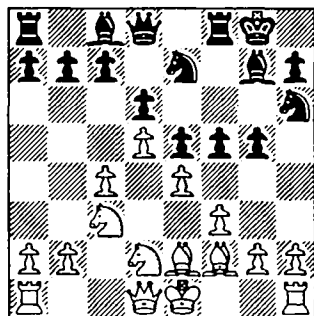


Diagram 16
Very double-edged

This line is often known as the Gligoric System after the world class Yugoslav grandmaster and King's Indian expert Svetozar Gligoric. He was the first to popularise it. These days a lot of strong players use it occasionally, including the 3 K's Korchnoi, Karpov and Kasparov, but very few play it all the time.

What is the thinking behind 7 Be3?

The main idea is to avoid the theoretical battles that arise after 7 0-0 Nc6 without having to either exchange on e5 or block the centre with d5. The point is that the position after 7 Be3 Nc6 8 d5 Ne7 9 Nd2! is favourable for White as he has managed to post his dark-squared bishop and the king's knight on their ideal squares. Normally he can have one or the other but not both. The only problem with 7 Be3 is that Black can play 7...Ng4 forcing the bishop to move again. This leads to highly complex strategical battles as can be seen from the material below.

7...Ng4

Black accepts the challenge White has offered. There are a number of important alternatives:

- 1) 7...Na6 8 0-0 transposes to Chapter 2. This is a perfectly reasonable way for Black to play if that line is in his repertoire.
- 2) 7...h6!? is a favourite of John Nunn who raised its profile by using it in against top class opposition. The idea is to play ...Ng4 but without allowing White to play Bg5. The main line runs 8 0-0 Ng4 9 Bc1 Nc6 10 d5 Ne7 11 Ne1 f5 12 Bxg4 fxg4 with a most unusual kingside pawn structure. Black will now play ...g6-g5 and ...Ng6-f4 while White will seek his fortune on the queenside. Most theoretical sources agree that White has slightly the better chances.
- 3) 7...exd4 is not such a bad move as Black is often able to create

counterplay by a quick ...c7-c6 and ...d6-d5. For example, 8 Nxd4 Re8 9 f3 c6 10 Qd2 (10 Bf2!?) 10...d5 11 exd5 cxd5 12 0-0 Nc6 13 c5 and now 13...Rxe3!? is the famous exchange sacrifice that first occurred in Karpov-Kasparov, New York 1990 (11th game of the world championship match).

8 Bg5 f6

Now White's bishop has to move again but Black's knight on g4 is also awkwardly placed.

9 Bh4

The most common. The bishop remains on the kingside and will be looking to eventually settle on f2 (after moves like Nd2 and f3). Some players prefer to go home with the bishop. 9 Bc1 is seen in Game 6.

9...Nc6

9...g5 10 Bg3 Nh6 is an interesting alternative after which White usually blocks the centre with 11 d5 or exchanges queens with 11 dxe5 dxe5 12 Qxd8 Rxd8 13 Nd5 Na6 14 0-0-0 Be6. The former is the more promising strategy.

10 d5 Ne7 11 Nd2 Nh6 12 f3 g5

Black can also slow down White on the queenside with 12...c5!?. One possible continuation is 13 Rb1 with the idea of b4 while another is to change the character of the game by playing 13 dxc6!? bxc6 14 b4.

13 Bf2 f5 (Diagram 16)

This very double-edged position is the subject of Game 5.

Theoretical?

It is not one of the more theoretical lines of the King's Indian and there is plenty of scope for improvisation by both sides. However, as we shall see below it is a line that scores very heavily for White so Black is definitely advised to learn a system.

Statistics

With 7 Be3 White has scored 62% from over 3000 games. Many Black players appear to be all at sea in this line. For example there are over 400 games with 7...Nc6 8 d5 Ne7 9 Nd2, the line I warned about in the Introduction. Here White scores a massive 75%. Against 7...Ng4 White scores 58%, still good but within the bounds of respectability.

Illustrative Games

Game 5

□ Shulman ■ Bakhtadze

Holon 1995

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Be2 e5 7 Be3 Ng4 8 Bg5 f6 9 Bh4 Nc6 10 d5 Ne7 11 Nd2 Nh6 12 f3 g5 13 Bf2 f5 14 c5

Few White players are willing to castle in this position but there is a sizeable group who try and block the kingside by playing 14 h3 Ng6 15 g4. After 15...fxg4 16 hxg4 Nh4 17 Rh2 c5! the chances are about equal. Both sides have good outposts on the kingside. White will follow up with Nf1-g3-f5 and Black with ...Nf7-h8-g6-f4.

14...g4

14...Ng6 is also played quite often. White usually plays 15 g3 to keep the knight out of f4 after which Black has an interesting pawn sacrifice: 15...g4 16 fxg4 f4! with attacking chances on the f-file.

15 fxg4 Nxg4 16 Bxg4 fxg4 17 0-0 Ng6 18 Nc4

In order to avoid the line in the next note White could have played 18 cxd6 cxd6 19 Nc4. John Nunn believes that Black is OK after 19...Qc7, although his is a minority view.

18...a6?!

Black is worried about White taking on d6 and playing Nb5. However, he would have done better to play 18...dxc5! 19 Bxc5 Rxf1+ 20 Qxf1 b6 21 Be3 Ba6 with a roughly level game. The text creates a hole on b6 that White is quick to take advantage of.

19 Be3 Nf4 20 g3 Nh3+ 21 Kg2 (Diagram 17)

In this position White has a clear advantage. The knight on h3 may look menacing but it has no support. The black pawn on g4 actually blocks lines on the kingside and prevents Black from creating any serious threats. The open f-file is only good for exchanging pieces and the more pieces that are exchanged the more pronounced White's advantage on the queenside will become.

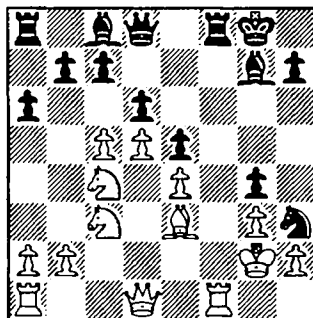


Diagram 17
Black has no counterplay

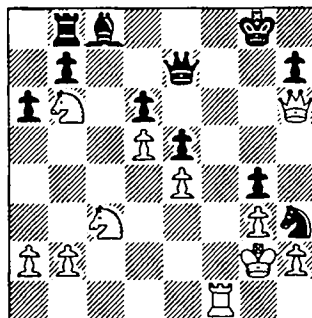


Diagram 18
White attacks on the kingside!

21...Bf6 22 cxd6 cxd6 23 Nb6 Bg5!?

Black seeks to complicate the game but White keeps his cool.

24 Rxf8+ Qxf8 25 Qe2!